Quick Start Guide: AI in Education

For the time-pressed educator

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Quick Start Guide: AI in Education

Reading time: 5 minutes
For: Educators who want the essentials without the deep dive

The 3 Things You Need to Know

1. AI is a Tool, Not a Replacement

- AI assists with tasks; it doesn't replace your expertise
- Your judgment is more important, not less
- Think "assistant," not "autopilot"

2. AI Makes Mistakes (Often Confidently)

- Can generate plausible but incorrect information
- Doesn't understand context like humans do
- **Always verify critical information**

3. Start Small, Stay Practical

- Pick one repetitive task
- Test AI assistance
- Evaluate results
- Adjust and repeat

What is AI in 2 Minutes

AI (Artificial Intelligence) = Software that learns patterns from data to perform tasks that typically need human intelligence.

For educators, this means: - Tools that can draft content, answer questions, summarize text - Not magic, not conscious—just pattern-matching at scale - Requires human oversight and expertise

Examples you've heard of: ChatGPT, Claude, Microsoft Copilot, Gemini

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What AI Can Do for You Right Now

Time-Savers (Low Risk)

- Generate discussion questions
- Draft assignment rubrics
- Summarize long readings
- Create multiple-choice questions
- Format references

Use with Care (Medium Risk)

- Draft feedback comments
- Create case studies
- Explain complex concepts
- Generate lesson plans
- Write practice problems

Avoid (High Risk)

- Final grading decisions
- Handling student data
- Medical/legal advice
- Replacing human connection

Your First AI Experiment (15 Minutes)

Step 1: Pick a Task (2 min)

Choose something simple and low-stakes: - Generate 3 discussion questions for next week's topic - Summarize a 5-page reading into bullet points - Draft a sample email to students about an assignment

Step 2: Write Your First Prompt (3 min)

Bad prompt: "Make some questions"

Good prompt: "Generate 3 discussion questions for a second-year marketing course on consumer behavior. Focus on ethical considerations. Make them open-ended to encourage debate."

Formula: Task + Context + Specifics + Constraints

Step 3: Evaluate the Output (5 min)

Ask yourself: - Is this accurate? (Verify 1-2 key facts) - Does it fit my context? (Would this work for MY students?) - What's missing? (What would I need to add?) - What's wrong? (Any obvious errors?)

Step 4: Refine or Use (5 min)

- Edit the output to match your voice
- Add specific examples from your experience
- Remove anything that doesn't fit
- Use what works, discard what doesn't

The 5-Second Quality Check

Before using any AI output, ask:

1. **Would I be comfortable defending this to a colleague?**
2. **Can I verify the key claims?**
3. **Does this sound like me or generic content?**

If you answer "no" to any, revise before using.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

Blind Trust

- Accepting AI output without review
- **Fix:** Always verify critical information

Too Vague

- "Tell me about marketing"
- **Fix:** Be specific: "Explain segmentation for first-year business students using retail examples"

Perfectionism

- Expecting AI to produce final drafts
- **Fix:** Think "first draft" or "starting point"

Over-Sharing

- Pasting student work or confidential data
- **Fix:** Use anonymized examples only

When to Use AI in Your Workflow

Before class: Generate ideas, draft materials, create examples
During class: (Generally avoid—focus on human interaction)
After class: Draft feedback, summarize discussions, plan next session
For assessment: Generate practice questions, draft rubrics (never final grading)

Red Flags: When AI Gets It Wrong

Watch for: - **Made-up facts** (hallucinations) - **Outdated information** (AI training has a cutoff date) - **Generic advice** that doesn't fit your context - **Overly confident tone** masking uncertainty - **Missing nuance** from your discipline

Your expertise is the filter.

One-Week Challenge

Day 1: Generate discussion questions for one topic
Day 2: Summarize one reading
Day 3: Draft a rubric outline
Day 4: Create practice problems
Day 5: Write a sample student feedback paragraph

Each day: Spend 10 minutes, evaluate results, note what worked

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Resources to Keep Learning

Minimal time: - Workshop handouts (you'll receive these) - Try one new prompt per week

Some time: - Read the full pre-reading materials (30 min total) - Experiment with one tool (ChatGPT, Claude, or Copilot)

More time: - Join peer discussions - Pilot one AI-assisted activity in your course - Share results with colleagues

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The Bottom Line

You don't need to become an AI expert.

You need to: 1. Understand what AI can and can't do 2. Try it for one small task 3. Apply your expertise to evaluate outputs 4. Build gradually from there

Your teaching expertise + AI assistance = Better outcomes for students

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Workshop Prep Checklist

- ☐ Bring a laptop/tablet
- ☐ Think of one repetitive task you'd like to streamline
- ☐ Have one assessment in mind to "stress-test"
- ☐ Come with questions (no question too basic!)

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Remember: Everyone starts somewhere. The goal isn't perfection—it's progress.